There were some newcomers, too, whom Humayun had recruited during his long exile: Bairam Khan's brother-in-law Wali Beg and his two sons Husain Quli and Ismail Quli; some Uzbek warriors, including Abdullah Khan and a swashbuckling homosexual called Ali Quli Shaibani; and Shah Abul Ma'ali, a man of gorgeous looks and treacherous sensibility, whom Humayun had recently adopted as a favourite. Finally, there was Akbar, who, for all his precocious experience of betrayal, cannot have suspected how much trouble many of these men would soon give him – nor how many of them he would have killed.

If Akbar was innocent of his future, Humayun may have guessed at it. At one point during the journey, Humayun called for his son. Jouher was sent to bathe and dress the prince, and bring him along. Akbar was twelve years old and he bristled, as any twelve-year-old would, at the idea of being bathed by the retainer. 'I cannot bathe, nor appear naked before you,' he declared. The prince got ready – 'in private' – and went to meet his father.

Humayun was sitting under a clear sky, facing the moon as it sank into the dark horizon. When Akbar arrived, Humayun asked him to sit before him. The boy would have eclipsed the moon. The emperor began to read from the Quran, and at the end of each verse he looked at his son and '*breathed*' upon him, each time 'so delighted and happy, it might be said that he had then acquired all the good fortune of this world, and the blessings of the next'.[70]

There are several fleeting moments in the chronicles that reveal the love between father and son. Humayun's giddy dance when he saw Akbar's horoscope. The little game he arranged to reunite Akbar with his mother, Hamida. A passing observation in Jouher's memoirs, of Humayun kissing Akbar's forehead and eyebrows when they met after yet another Kamran-induced separation. Humayun's worry for his son's education and his relief at the prince's growing ability to command. And, finally, this mystical and lovely ceremony: an almost ethereal moment of quiet, a father's prayers on his breath, blessing his child.

There was little quiet ahead of them. Between February 1555, when Humayun's army entered Lahore, and July of that year, when Humayun was enthroned in Delhi, the Mughal army fought four battles of varying intensity in Punjab, against Afghan armies trying to keep them out. The last